

thought about it, I recognized that the primary source of my exhaustion was relational. Due to the needs placed on me day-to-day and the conversational, problem-solving, compassion-focused, empathy efforts exerted, I was most depleted relationally. Working in a residential setting with clients very fresh in their recovery process and managing a team of employees, I was “on” nearly 24/7, and it was taking a toll on me. Of course, my friend’s next question to me was “How can you care for yourself relationally?” It was a novel concept, and yet it made so much sense! Of course, I should respond to the need with something congruent with the need!

While I had been isolating, what I really needed was to spend time with trustworthy, caring friends where there was reciprocity in the relationship (not just relational demands). This explained why the bubble baths and books weren’t cutting it. They’re good and all, but they were missing the mark in actually resolving the core issue.

So, I re-engaged in Sunday evening dinners with friends and had phone calls with loved ones during my long commutes. And while eventually there was a shelf-life to that job for me, I experienced symptom relief, perspective shifts, and a lightness inside myself as I responded to my needs in a way that matched the need.

All of this occurred because curiosity was modeled and encouraged for me. When I lacked inquisitiveness and simply reacted, I did the exact opposite of what would help me. My “natural instinct” and social media’s encouraged self-care efforts of isolation, TV-bingeing, and even bubble baths were not the right solution, and I would not have realized this if it weren’t for slowing down and asking nonjudgmental, non-leading questions.

Since this experience, I have been on a journey of discovery. Like most journeys, it has included pit stops, wrong turns, and tantrums, but overall I am learning to ask myself questions. Before assumption and action, I am slowing down and reflecting on the situation, what’s happening, and what this means about me and my response. If that’s not Maslow’s tippy-top triangle of self-actualization, I don’t know what is!

Of course, this story of curiosity unearthing deeper needs and tangible solutions doesn’t only apply to feeling burnt out at work but paints a picture of the power of being curious—with ourselves and others in all scenarios. Since this is something we can implement in every aspect of our